NOTRUMP OPENINGS

These 100 Deals are all about hands that are either opened 1NT or 2NT, or perhaps overcalled 1NT or 2NT. Some of them end up being played at a Notrump contract, but others are played with a trump suit.

The proficiency level for the Deals is Intermediate/Advanced, both in the Bidding and Declarer play.

ABOUT THE DEALS

With both hands visible and the opening lead noted you are asked to make a Plan for each Deal. You should think this through just as if you were at the table.

All of the Notrump Plans include a Winner Count and all Suit Plans include a Loser Count.

During the Bidding section you are in the South position. As a result of that some of the Deals would end up with your partner North as the Declarer.

ABOUT THE BIDDING

Normal 4-3-2-1 point count is used, with 1 length point added for any card more than 4 in any suit.
1NT Opening: 15-17 points
2NT Opening: 20-21 points
1NT Overcall: 15-18 points, at least 1, (preferably 2), stoppers in their suit
2NT Overcall over a Weak 2-bid: 15-18 points, at least 1, (preferably 2), stoppers

Stayman convention is used extensively.

Jacoby Transfers are used extensively.
In addition to the standard 2♦ transfer to ♥ and 2♥ transfer to ♠ we also use a 2♠ transfer to 3♣.

The **lebensohl** convention is used when opponents overcall your side's 1NT opening.
Since this is not a standard for many of you, a brief explanation/comment is given when it occurs.

You can go either go through the deals in order, or use the Navigation Bar at left.

Board: 1
Dealer: **North**

Contract: 6NT
Declarer: North
Lead: ♣9

Board: 2
Dealer: **East**

Contract: 3NT
Declarer: East
Lead: ♦Q

Board: 3
Dealer: **East**

Contract: 3NT
Declarer: South
Lead: ♥8

Board: 4
Dealer: **East**

Contract: 4♥
Declarer: West
Lead: ♠10

Board 1
North Deals
None Vul

	♠ A K J ♥ A Q 3 ♦ A 4 3 ♣ K 10 4 2	
♠ 10 9 6 3 ♥ 10 8 5 2 ♦ Q 10 9 ♣ J 6	N W E S	♠ Q 8 2 ♥ J 6 4 ♦ J 7 5 ♣ 9 8 7 3
	♠ 7 5 4 ♥ K 9 7 ♦ K 8 6 2 ♣ A Q 5	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
	2NT	Pass	4NT
Pass	6NT		
All Pass			

6NT by North
Lead: ♣9

Partner's 4NT bid is not Blackwood, it is the Quantitative 4NT. He is unsure whether to bid 6NT or not, so is inviting you to do so.

With 20 points you are supposed to pass. With 21 points you are supposed to bid 6NT. The evaluations probably aren't that accurate, but at least you have an excuse to bid 6NT.

North plays 6NT. East leads the ♣9. West plays the ♣J which you take with your ♣K.

Winner List: ♠ = 2 : ♥ = 3 : ♦ = 2 : ♣ = 4 :: Total = 11

There are two places you might find your twelfth winner. You can finesse West for the ♠Q; this is a 50% chance. Or, the ♦s might split 3-3; this is about a 40% chance.

If you try the ♠ finesse and it fails you will go down even if the ♦s are splitting 3-3.

If you play ♦A, ♦K then another ♦, a 4-2 ♦ split will defeat you even if the ♠Q was with West.

Two chances are always better than one. The way to take both chances is to duck a ♦ at trick 2. Win whatever the defenders play next and then test the ♦s. If they do split your last ♦ will be trick #12. But if they don't split you can still try the ♠ finesse.

Ducking the ♦ was the correct play - not just because it worked, but because it gave you the opportunity to try an alternate method if it didn't work.

Board 2
East Deals
N-S Vul

	♠ Q 10 5 4 ♥ A 8 4 2 ♦ 9 6 3 ♣ 10 7	
♠ A 9 ♥ Q 10 6 3 ♦ 8 5 2 ♣ Q J 9 4		♠ K 8 6 2 ♥ 7 5 ♦ A K 7 ♣ A K 6 3
	♠ J 7 3 ♥ K J 9 ♦ Q J 10 4 ♣ 8 5 2	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
		1NT	Pass
2♣	Pass	2♠	Pass
2NT	Pass	3NT	
All Pass			

3NT by East
Lead: ♦Q

With 9 points you have just enough to respond. And with a 4-card Major suit you should use Stayman so you bid 2♣. Partner duly replies 2♠.

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You don't have a 4-4 ♥ fit, so you invite the notrump game by bidding 2NT. Partner raises to 3NT.

The contract would be 3NT played by West.

East plays 3NT and South leads the ♦Q. Should you win or hold up?

A pretty good argument against holding up could be that they might switch to ♠s. However, say you do in fact hold up and that South does in fact continue ♦s with North following suit.

Winner List: ♠ = 2 : ♥ = 0 : ♦ = 2 : ♣ = 4 :: Total = 8

Don't worry any more about the ♦s since there is nothing more you can do. Instead, worry about where that one more winner is going to come from. The answer will have to be: *from the ♥ suit*.

You might be tempted to take your 4 ♣ tricks right away, but avoid the temptation. The ♣ suit is your convenient transportation back and forth between hands.

You will have to lose at least 2 ♥ tricks in order to set up 1 winner, and by the time you do that the defenders will have established at least 1 more ♦ trick. What that means is that you cannot afford 3 ♥ losers. So how will you play the ♥s?

You should play South for the ♥J plus one of the big ones. This is a better chance than playing him for both the ♥ A K. So play a ♥ toward dummy and insert the ♥10 when South plays low. North wins with the ♥A and clears the ♦s. Play another ♥ toward dummy's ♥Q. South can take his ♥K and cash his ♦ winner but dummy's ♥Q will be your ninth trick.

There were two ♥ distributions which would allow you to make this contract.

South could hold both the ♥A and ♥K, in which case leading toward dummy's ♥Q would be the winning play.

South could hold **EITHER** ♥ A J x **OR**♥ K J x in which case finessing dummy's ♥J would be the winning play. This is the more likely distribution of the two.

Board 3
East Deals
None Vul

♠ 8 7 3
♥ A 6
♦ J 8 5 2
♣ A Q 6 2

♠ 6 4 2
♥ 8 3
♦ 9 7 4
♣ J 10 7 4 3



♠ K Q J 10
♥ K J 9 7 5 4
♦ A
♣ 9 5

♠ A 9 5
♥ Q 10 2
♦ K Q 10 6 3
♣ K 8

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
		1♥	1NT
Pass	3NT		
All Pass			

3NT by South
Lead: ♥8

You should not make a takeout double with three cards in their suit. A 2♦ overcall would be a reasonable choice. But with 15 points, balanced, and a stopper in ♥s a 1NT overcall is probably better.

Partner bids 3NT.

South plays 3NT. As expected, West leads his partner's ♥ suit.

Winner List: ♠ = 1 : ♥ = 1/2 : ♦ = 0 : ♣ = 3 :: Total = 5/6

You need at least 4 ♦ winners.

If you play low from dummy on the ♥ lead East can win the ♥K but this will give you an extra ♥ stopper. He could drive out dummy's ♥A at trick 2, but you would then establish ♦s and make an overtrick!

But who said East would play another ♥ after winning the ♥K? What if he wins the ♥K and switches to ♠s? They might then win 3 ♠ tricks to go with their ♥K and ♦A.

Instead you should grab the first trick with dummy's ♥A and start playing ♦s. East will take the ♦A but you still have the ♠A and ♥Q as stoppers.

Just look at East's hand. If you duck the ♥A it will be crystal clear to him that he can defeat the contract by winning the ♥K and then switching to the ♠K.

Don't give him the chance.

Board 4
East Deals
Both Vul

	♠ 10 2 ♥ K 8 3 ♦ 10 8 5 4 ♣ Q 10 6 2	
♠ 8 5 ♥ Q J 9 7 6 4 2 ♦ 9 ♣ K 9 4		♠ K 6 3 ♥ A 10 5 ♦ A 7 6 2 ♣ A 7 5
	♠ A Q J 9 7 4 ♥ — ♦ K Q J 3 ♣ J 8 3	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
		1NT	2♠
4♥			
All Pass			

4♥ by West
Lead: ♠10

You would really like to have a transfer bid in this situation, to make East bid ♥s.

But you don't have one, so you just bid 4♥ yourself.

West plays 4♥. North leads the ♠10. You play low in dummy and North holds the trick. He continues the suit and South takes the ♠Q and then plays the ♠A.

Loser List: ♠ = 2 : ♥ = 1 : ♦ = 0 : ♣ = 1 :: Total = 4

You've already lost the 2 ♠s. If North has the ♥K you might avoid a loser there. You don't have a winner on which to discard the ♣ loser.

If South has the ♥K it will have to be a singleton to help you, so it is more logical to play North for the ♥K. But if North does have the ♥K it will do you no good to ruff South's ♠A, North will over-ruff and you would still have that ♣ loser.

So do it this way instead. Discard the ♣ loser on South's ♠A! Another ♠ from South won't hurt you since dummy would be able to over-ruff North. Whatever South plays you can win, then finesse North out of his ♥K.

It was said earlier that you didn't have a winner on which you could discard the ♣ loser.

That was true, so instead you were able to discard it on a loser!